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AU PAIR

A Comprehensive Course

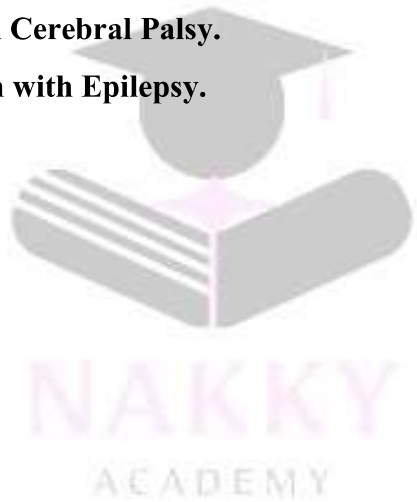
First Edition 2023



MODULE FOUR: CHILD CARE FOR CHILDREN WITH SPECIAL NEEDS.

KEY LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- **Defining and recognizing special needs.**
- **Common types of Special needs.**
- **Manage Children with Autism Spectrum Disorder.**
- **How to handle kids with Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder?**
- **Understanding Down Syndrome.**
- **Handling children with Cerebral Palsy.**
- **Taking care of children with Epilepsy.**



1.0 SPECIAL NEEDS

1.1 Who is a Child with Special Needs?

According to the Child Care Law Centre, a child with special needs is one who requires some form of special care due to physical, mental, emotional or health reasons. Because each child is unique and has unique needs, no single approach to caring for children with special needs can be applied to all children, even those with the same disability or special need. Every child is a special person, but some children may need special care due to physical, emotional, health, or development needs. The kinds of special needs vary greatly. They may be simple allergies, developmental delays, a diagnosed disability, or a serious illness. Here are some of the broad categories of special needs:

1.2 What is Disability?

Disabilities is an umbrella term, covering impairments, activity limitations, and participation restrictions. Impairment is a problem in body function or structure; an activity limitation is a difficulty encountered by an individual in executing a task or action; while a participation restriction is a problem experienced by an individual in involvement in life situations. Thus, disability is a complex phenomenon, reflecting an interaction between features of a person's body and features of the society in which he or she lives.

In other words, it is the consequence of an impairment that may be physical, cognitive, mental, sensory, emotional, developmental, or some combination of these. A disability may be present from birth, or occur during a person's lifetime. According to (Weitz, 2001) disability refers to a reduced ability to perform tasks one would normally do at a given stage of life and that may result in stigmatization or discrimination against the person with disabilities.

An individual may also qualify as disabled if they have had an impairment in the past or is seen as disabled based on a personal or group standard or norm. Such impairments may include physical, sensory, and cognitive or developmental disabilities. Mental disorders (also known as psychiatric or psychosocial disability) and various types of chronic disease may also qualify as disabilities

1.3 Common Developmental Disabilities in Children

Many professionals describe developmental disabilities as physical, emotional, or intellectual disorders that start before birth or in early childhood. However, it's a tricky definition because the terms developmental disability, neurodevelopmental disability, developmental delay, and learning disability are very close in meaning and often overlap.

Children with developmental delays are often born with them. "Issues may emerge later in life with similar outcomes, but they are called acquired disabilities," explains Rebecca Mannis, PhD, a learning specialist and consultant at Ivy Prep Learning Center.

When interacting with a practitioner who is assessing your child's challenges, it's important to remember that different practitioners may use different terms to describe the same thing. While developmental disabilities are often lifelong, early diagnosis and treatment can make a tremendous difference in a child's life. Even when challenges persist, practitioners can provide tools and suggest accommodations. Some of the issues most commonly labeled as developmental disabilities include intellectual disabilities (low IQ), autism, and cerebral palsy.

1.3.1 Intellectual Disabilities

Intellectual disabilities (ID) relate to a person's ability to learn and perform tasks of daily living at an expected level.² In other words, a person with an intellectual disability has unusually low intelligence as measured by IQ tests, behavioral observations, and other diagnostic tools. A person is generally considered to have an intellectual disability if their IQ score is 70 or under; the average IQ in the U.S. is around 100.³

"When we think about most developmental disabilities, such as dyslexia and ADHD, we're thinking about a person with average or above average intelligence," Dr. Mannis explains.

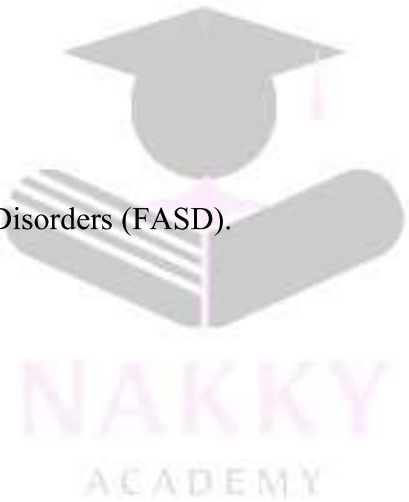
"There is some underlying issue, however, that makes learning and focus more difficult. Those issues impact their cognitive functioning and academics."

However, when a person has an intellectual disability, their overall skills might be greatly reduced. Intellectual disabilities can exist on their own, but they may also be part of a wider diagnosis. For example, people with autism may or may not also have intellectual disabilities. It

can also be difficult to properly test IQ in a person who is nonverbal, or who has limited ability to write or speak.

1.3.2 Here are some of the special health care needs or developmental disabilities that occur among children birth through 3:

- Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD).
- Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD).
- Behavior Disorders.
- Cerebral Palsy.
- Cleft Lip and Palate
- Cystic Fibrosis.
- Down Syndrome.
- Fetal Alcohol Spectrum Disorders (FASD).
- Hearing Disorders.
- Hemophilia.
- Intellectual Disabilities.
- Learning Disabilities.
- Paraplegia.
- Quadriplegia.
- Seizure Disorders.
- Sensory Processing Disorder.
- Spina Bifida.
- Substance-Exposed Infants.
- Vision Impairment.



- Traumatic Brain Injury.

1.4 5 Common Types of Special Needs Children

1.4.1 Autism

Autism is defined as a developmental disability that persists through a person's life, which affects their ability in making sense of things around them as well as communicating with other people. Common symptoms usually include intense reactions to sounds, smells and lights, delayed language development and a preference to be alone.

While autism may vary across each individual, depending on the severity of the disorder, it can be significantly reduced with early intervention from their caregivers. There are many programs that are focused in teaching the core missing skills from these autistic children, including social interaction, self-regulation and to be more independent learners. Mozart, the composer, and artist Andy Warhol were said to have autism.

1.4.2 ADHD

ADHD, or Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder, is a medical condition where those afflicted suffer from differences of brain development that affect attention and self-control. Children with ADHD may find it much harder to wait, listen and follow directions, when compared to their peers. They also may be impulsive, rushing through things and making careless mistakes. As many young children are often restless and distractible by nature, parents shouldn't be too quick to conclude that their child may have ADHD. However, if the medical condition is diagnosed early on, ADHD can be easily treated with a combination of medication, therapy and coaching. Some famous people with ADHD include Justin Timberlake, Jamie Oliver, and Michael Phelps.

1.4.3 Down Syndrome

Down syndrome occurs when an extra copy of chromosome is produced in an embryo, causing complications in the course of development and brings about certain physical characteristics that are common amongst afflicted children, such as flat noses, low muscle tone and small ears. Most

of them will also display mild to moderate issues with their abilities in thinking and reasoning. Down syndrome is a lifelong condition, which differs in each individual. Some may grow to eventually live independently, while others may need regular supervision from their caregivers. With early detection, treatment and therapy, children suffering from Down syndrome can slowly thrive in society without any significant problems.

1.4.4 Cerebral Palsy

Cerebral palsy is a neurological disorder that happens when a growing child sustains a brain injury, or suffers abnormal brain development. It can happen before, during or immediately after birth. Usual symptoms will include a wide range of loss in body movement, muscle control and coordination, as well as basic motor skills.

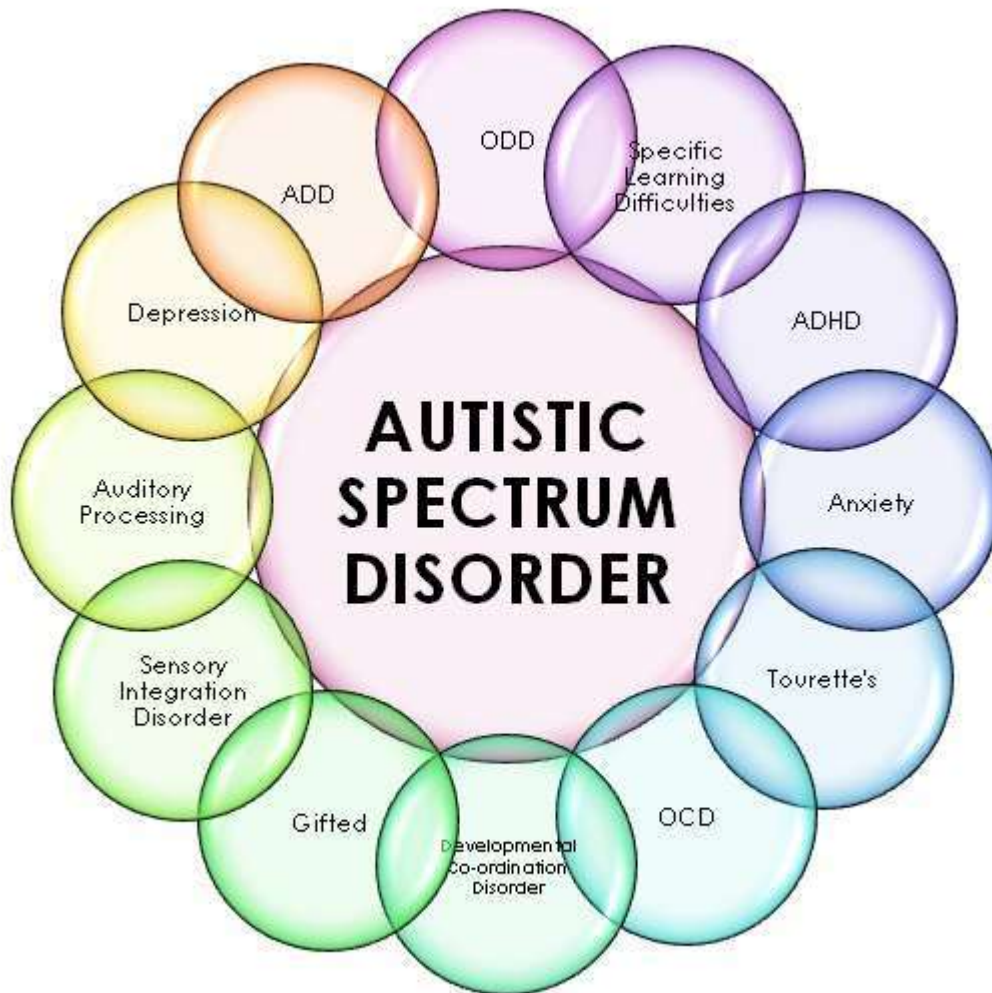
Where the brain damage done is permanent and will not heal over-time, the side effects of cerebral palsy can be managed by a combination of medications, therapies and assistive technology. Depending on the degree of the disorder, some children with cerebral palsy may go on to lead unassisted lives, while others may become bedridden and would require constant care.

1.4.5 Epilepsy

Epilepsy stems off from neurological disorders that affect the central nervous system, which hampers the electric signals that the nerve cells use to control the body's functions, senses and thoughts. This disorder can be brought upon by a severe head injury, meningitis, or genetics passed on by either parent.

Children with epilepsy are prone to seizures, which can include uncontrollable jerking movements, loss of consciousness or even unexplainable fear and anxiety. This can be controlled with a mixture of anti-epileptic drugs, dieting and surgery (if necessary). There may even be a chance for some children to naturally outgrow their epilepsy by their teenage years. Former United States President Theodore Roosevelt, author Charles Dickens and singer Susan Boyle had and have suffered from epilepsy.

2.0 AUTISM SPECTRUM DISORDER



Autism is an umbrella description which includes Autistic disorder, Asperger's syndrome and atypical autism. Autism affects the way information is taken in and stored in the brain. People with autism typically have difficulties in verbal and non-verbal communication, social interactions and other activities. Impairments usually exist across three main areas of functioning:

- Social interaction
- Communication, and
- Behavior (restricted interests and repetitive behaviors).

Many people with an autism spectrum disorder also have sensory sensitivities, i.e. over or under sensitivity to sight, touch, taste, smell, sound, temperature or pain.

2.1 Social Communication and Interaction Skills

Social communication and interaction skills can be challenging for people with ASD. Examples of social communication and social interaction characteristics related to ASD can include;

- Avoids or does not keep eye contact.
- Does not respond to name by 9 months of age.
- Does not show facial expressions like happy, sad, angry, and surprised by 9 months of age.
- Does not play simple interactive games like pat-a-cake by 12 months of age.
- Uses few or no gestures by 12 months of age (for example, does not wave goodbye)
- Does not share interests with others by 15 months of age (for example, shows you an object that they like).
- Does not point to show you something interesting by 18 months of age.
- Does not notice when others are hurt or upset by 24 months of age.
- Does not notice other children and join them in play by 36 months of age.
- Does not pretend to be something else, like a teacher or superhero, during play by 48 months of age.
- Does not sing, dance, or act for you by 60 months of age.

2.1.1 Restricted or Repetitive Behaviors or Interests

People with ASD have behaviors or interests that can seem unusual. These behaviors or interests set ASD apart from conditions defined by problems with social communication and interaction only.

Examples of restricted or repetitive behaviors and interests related to ASD can include;

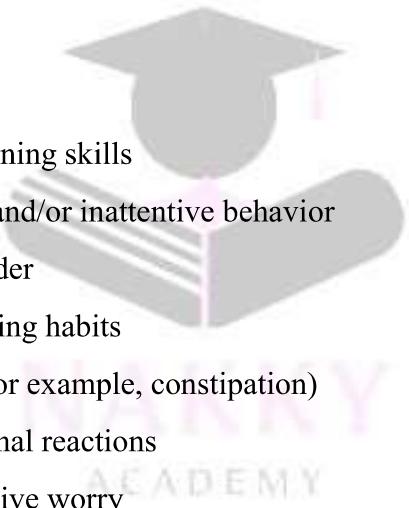
- Lines up toys or other objects and gets upset when order is changed.
- Repeats words or phrases over and over (called echolalia).

- Plays with toys the same way every time.
- Is focused on parts of objects (for example, wheels).
- Gets upset by minor changes.
- Has obsessive interests.
- Must follow certain routines.
- Flaps hands, rocks body, or spins self in circles.
- Has unusual reactions to the way things sound, smell, taste, look, or feel.

2.1.2 Other Characteristics

Most people with ASD have other related characteristics. These might include;

- Delayed language skills
- Delayed movement skills
- Delayed cognitive or learning skills
- Hyperactive, impulsive, and/or inattentive behavior
- Epilepsy or seizure disorder
- Unusual eating and sleeping habits
- Gastrointestinal issues (for example, constipation)
- Unusual mood or emotional reactions
- Anxiety, stress, or excessive worry
- Lack of fear or more fear than expected.



2.2 Taking Care of Children with Autism Spectrum Disorder



Taking care of children with autism requires patience, understanding, and specialized knowledge of the condition. Remember, every child with autism is unique, and what works for one child may not work for another. It's important to be patient, understanding, and willing to adapt your approach to meet the needs of the child you are caring for.

- **Create a structured routine:** Children with autism often thrive on routine and predictability. Creating a consistent daily schedule can help them feel more comfortable and secure.
- **Use visual aids:** Many children with autism are visual learners. Using pictures, charts, and other visual aids can help them understand and follow routines.
- **Simplify communication:** Children with autism may struggle with verbal communication. Speak clearly and concisely, using simple language and short sentences. Using gestures or visual aids to supplement verbal communication can also be helpful.
- **Encourage social interaction:** Many children with autism struggle with social interaction. Encourage them to engage in social activities, but be patient and understanding if they struggle.

- **Address sensory issues:** Children with autism may have sensory processing issues, meaning they may be hypersensitive or hyposensitive to certain sensations. Be aware of their sensory needs and adjust their environment as needed to help them feel more comfortable.
- **Be patient.** It often takes a child with ASD longer to process information. You may need to slow down your conversation to their speed. Long pauses can be helpful.
- **Teach the child how to express anger without being too aggressive.** Children with ASD should know that they don't have to hold their anger and frustration inside.
- **Be persistent but resilient.** Don't let your feelings get hurt if the child does not respond to you as you'd like. Children with ASD may have trouble both showing and controlling their emotions. They can be blunt in their responses. Don't take this personally.
- **Always stay positive.** Children with ASD respond best to positive reinforcement. Be sure to talk about or reward good behavior often. Be generous with compliments for good behavior.
- **Ignore irritating attention-getting behavior.** A child with ASD may act badly at times to get you to focus on them. Ignoring this behavior is often the best way to prevent it. Also talk about and reward the child's good behavior often.
- **Interact through physical activity.** Children with ASD tend to have short attention spans. This is especially true when it comes to communicating. Running around and playing outside may be a better way of sharing time together. It will also let them relax and feel calmer.
- **Be affectionate and respectful.** Children with ASD often need a hug, just like other children. Sometimes they need this much more than other children. But some children don't like to be touched at all, even light contact can distress them. Respect their personal space. Never force physical affection on an unwilling child.
- **Show your love and interest.** Children with ASD may have trouble showing their feelings. But they still need to know that you love them. Go out of your way to express your interest, caring, and support.
- **Learn from the child.** Your child's special need and abilities may show you a way to look at the world that you've never considered. As difficult as it may be on some days,

relaxing, laughing, and enjoying the unique gift that is your child can provide both you and your family with many rewards.

- **Believe.** A child with autism is first and foremost a child. They are a growing person with unknown possibilities. Believe in what the child can do. Don't define the child by a diagnosis.
- **Arrange for specialized therapy:** Many children with autism benefit from specialized therapy, such as occupational therapy, speech therapy, and behavioral therapy. These therapies can help children develop social skills, communication skills, and coping mechanisms.

